



ANNUAL REPORT

COVERING THE PERIOD
JUNE 2023-JUNE 2024



Date of Establishment:

September 5th, 2017

Address:

Address: Rruga “Skënderbeg“ No. 8, Kati IV, Ap. 35/36. Tirana, Albania

Contacts:

 info@westernbalkansfund.org

 +355 42 400420

 westernbalkansfund.org

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About the Report

The Annual Report No. 6 covers the period from June 2023 to June 2024. The 6th WBF's Annual Report provides comprehensive insights into our strategic achievements, networking efforts, partnerships, and influential advocacy actions.

It also highlights the successful accomplishment of WBF's Theory of Change that through direct support to regional projects, it can improve good neighborly relations that can transcend geographical and cultural boundaries. Based on the Theory of Change, WBF managed to provide targeted, adapted grants and technical support to its target audience in order to creatively and jointly address the need and challenges for regional cooperation.

This Report is divided in six sections: Overall strategic achievements, WBF direct support through grant schemes, WBF's capacity and skills development, WBF networking and promotion, WBF Lessons Learned and WBF Good Governance.

The Report also highlights WBF's growing role as a supportive regional mechanism for Civil Society Organisations and as a focal point in supporting youth empowerment, educational exchanges, cultural heritage, environmental sustainability, human rights, and economic cooperation. Through direct support to a broad variety of stakeholders, the Fund creates and mobilizes both the capacity and the demand for regional cooperation and partnerships.

✦ This Annual Report will also highlight the successful diversification of our grant portfolio, a prime objective of the 2020-24 Strategic Development Strategy.

In close cooperation with the Council of Senior Officials, the Secretariat has launched new grant initiatives over the years. From a single Annual Call for Proposals in the first five years of the Fund's existence, we have evolved in 2024 to include separate calls for grassroots and new organizations, experienced and well-established CSOs, researchers and doctoral students, as well as individuals aiming to create cooperation networks in the region. ✦



Foreword

Throughout the reporting period covered in this Annual Report, the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) successfully implemented a responsive, adaptable, and impact-oriented program.

We continuously enhanced stakeholder engagement, effectiveness, and learning to drive regional cooperation within the Western Balkans. Through monitoring the progress of awarded grants for regional projects, WBF demonstrated tangible progress in fostering regional cooperation.

Our direct support continues to be widely recognized by governments, media, and civil society organizations, as well as the general public, indicating a growing endorsement for regional cooperation efforts. This recognition motivates us to believe in positive trends toward stabilizing regional relations.

Assessment of public perceptions towards regional cooperation and good neighborly relations, conducted through surveys and community dialogues, reveals significant progress in overcoming historical prejudices and fostering trust among communities.

Furthermore, increased participation rates in regional events such as cultural exchanges, educational programs, and community-based initiatives highlight a growing sense of social and cultural cohesion and trust in regional cooperation.

WBF Main figures 2017-24

11

Call for
Proposals

291

Provided
Grants

3040

Total
Applicants

10K

Stakeholders

35K

Followers

2.4M

Funds for
Grants

These achievements emphasize WBF's important role in promoting regional stability, prosperity, and integration.

We remain committed to supporting the WBF's journey towards a more cooperative and harmonious future in the region. In addition, our advocacy actions demonstrate the ongoing need for people-to-people links that enhance economic development and stability in the Western Balkans region.

In terms of grant making, WBF made notable progresses in diversifying its grant portfolio which includes MOVE Grant Scheme, Annual Grant Scheme, Empowering Regional Cooperation Grant Scheme showcasing our commitment to fostering sustainable regional cooperation.

Through active engagement of the WBF Secretariat team in mentoring and monitoring grants has led to continuous improvements in grant-making procedures, ensuring both effectiveness and efficiency.

In order to keep the pace, we have actively engaged with like-minded organizations, where we have jointly implemented advocacy actions and enhanced the capacities of direct beneficiaries through capacity-building support.

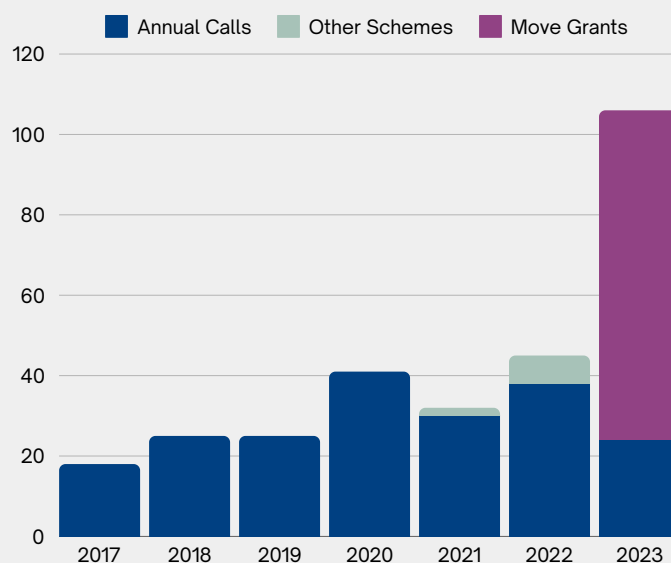
The Fund continues its growth trajectory, characterized by enhanced capabilities and streamlined processes and procedures and aims to further enhance operational capabilities and

and demonstrate the impact of its programs through data-driven decision-making, prioritizing the institutionalization of a Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning (MEL) system.

Moreover, initiatives such as strengthening mentorship roles, modernizing operations through improved systems, and increasing visibility through advocacy actions like the Regional Dialogue Sessions reflect our ongoing commitment to excellence.

We continue improving our operations, including advancements in human resources and digitalization efforts which highlights our commitment to accountability and excellence.

Overall, WBF continues to make significant progress in realizing its objectives and solidifying its position as an effective and accountable organization in advancing regional cooperation within the Western Balkans.



**list represents awarded grants by year awarded, not by implementation period*

Growing from a Regional Initiative to Regional **Powerhouse**

The number 7 is often considered lucky in many cultures due to its frequent appearance in nature, religion, and mythology.

There are seven days in a week, seven wonders of the world, and significant occurrences of this number in folklore and legends. For us, the number 7 holds special significance as well.

The seventh year of our establishment is a moment of celebration for all that we have achieved, but also a moment of reflection on what we can do better

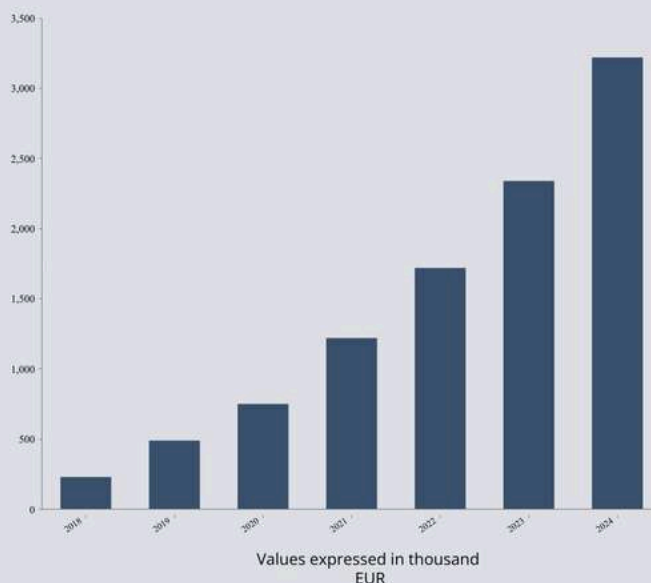
to further sustain and enhance cooperation and reconciliation in our region.

Back in 2017, the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) was founded with a vision to foster cooperation, strengthen neighborly relations, and pave the way for regional integration among Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Kosovo*, Montenegro, North Macedonia, and Serbia. Over the years, the Fund has embarked on a transformative journey, making significant strides toward fulfilling our mission.



*This designation is without prejudice to positions on status and is in line with UNSCR 1244 and the ICJ opinion on Kosovo Declaration of Independence.

Cumulative Support in EUR



As we enter our seventh year, we reflect on our progress and look forward to the future with a renewed commitment to fostering regional stability, prosperity, and integration. Our journey from a regional initiative to a regional powerhouse has been marked by continuous growth, adaptation, and impactful achievements. We are dedicated to building on this foundation and further enhancing our role in promoting cooperation and reconciliation throughout the Western Balkans.

A Vision of Unity - From the outset, the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) continues to be driven by a clear set of objectives: to enhance regional cooperation, support civil society, encourage cross-border projects, and contribute to the European Union (EU) integration process. These goals have guided our initiatives and projects, ensuring that every effort aligns with the broader vision of a more connected and cohesive Western Balkans.

This vision of unity has been the cornerstone of our work, shaping our strategies and inspiring our actions. By fostering collaboration and understanding among the countries of the Western Balkans, we aim to create a region that is not only more integrated but also more resilient and prosperous. Through our various programs and initiatives, we are committed to building a future where the Western Balkans can thrive as a unified and dynamic part of Europe.

We lead the change - Since its establishment, the WBF has grown from nothing to delivering over 250 grants, a testament to the rising demand and trust in regional initiatives. This significant achievement highlights our role as a key enabler of regional cooperation and development. The WBF works with civil society around the Western Balkan region to drive change by helping them turn bold ideas into

reality so they can deliver for the people of Western Balkan region. WBF does it by directly supporting regional initiatives, capacity development and advocacy unlocking the power of regional cooperation across all three and by sharing lessons learned on the ground through monitoring and evaluation, so everyone in the region can benefit.



We do build a more open, inclusive, and prosperous region for all the people

22 Mln

in Euros the overall amount requested by the WBF

The cumulative amount (In Euros) requested in grants by the applicants of the Western Balkans Fund

95%

of respondents
Reported an increased motivation to engage in regional cooperation

93%

indicated that their ability to forge partnerships across borders had improved



Winners of the 5th Call for Proposals (December 22)

291

Total Grants from 2017 to June 2024

90%

of respondents felt
confident in their
capacity to sustain
these partnerships

85%

developed new
projects as a result of
their involvement with
WBF initiatives

A significant indicator of WBF's success is the financial resources it operates with, with the support of its regional team operating in Tirana, successfully supported over 2.2 million euros in grants tackling some of the region's biggest challenges.

However, this figure represents only a fraction of the demand, which exceeds 20 million euros.

In a region of ever more complex challenges, WBF believes that diversity of backgrounds and culture that values and nurtures difference is a strength.

WBF remains dedicated to unlocking potential, not only for the Western Balkan region. This overwhelming interest highlights the crucial need for WBF's funding and the extensive impact of supported projects, forming a strong foundation for the continued relevance and expansion of the Fund.





Photo taken during the regional workshop with WBF grantees in December 2023

Expanding support through diversification of grant mechanisms -

Initially launched as a single grant scheme, WBF has now developed into a multifaceted grant portfolio comprising four distinct grant schemes, each tailored to address the diverse needs of the region. These grants provide long-established civil society organisations, grassroots initiatives, individual mobility, and PhD graduates or students. This expansion emphasizes WBF's dedication to inclusivity and comprehensive support for a wide range of stakeholders throughout the region. Our grants schemes are the ERC Grant Scheme, the Annual Call for Proposals, the WBF Move Grants and the Western Balkans-Visegrad Fellowship.

Not ONLY financial support – The WBF supports CSOs across the Western Balkans region not only through grant schemes but also by offering strong advocacy and capacity-building initiatives. The WBF with esteemed partners such as the Japanese Embassy in Tirana and International Visegrad Fund has conducted number of actions that provided unbiased support for .

advocacy actions, ensuring that critical regional issues are addressed objectively

WBF dedicates its time to understanding and exploring which causes need to be upheld or challenged, so it can ensure its interventions are both relevant and impactful. In addition, WBF finds it essential to build one-to-one relationships of trust and confidence with donors/partners for the sustained support of CSOs.

WBF offers comprehensive support beyond financial grants, what helps ensuring that CSOs operate effectively and ethically, ultimately contributing to the region's overall development and stability, whereas the Civil Society Organisations, associations, public administration, foundations, universities, arts and cultural entities, sports clubs, theatres, galleries, and similar entities are not only beneficiaries but also key stakeholders and participants in WBF's advocacy and capacity-building events.

Capacity development of Regional Cooperation Champions - In cooperation with the European Union and EU TACSO (Technical Assistance for Civil Society Organisations in the Western Balkans and Turkey), WBF organised a significant capacity-building event in December 2023, gathering participants from over 50 influential CSOs in the region.

Building on this successful experience, WBF will continue providing direct assistance to the capacity building of grassroots organisations over the next two years by organising Regional Debate Sessions in all the capitals of our Contracting Parties and in addition, starting from June 2024, WBF in partnership with the Italian Agency for Development and Cooperation to further enhance capacity-building events for CSOs in the region.

Way forward - The journey of the Western Balkans Fund stands as a testament to the transformative power of regional cooperation and sustained collaboration among our member countries.

With the unwavering commitment and support coming from the Ministries of Foreign Affairs, the WBF continued to achieve significant milestones in fostering harmony, empowering civil society, and promoting sustainable development. Nevertheless, the increase of financial support coming from donors and partners highlights the significance of WBF's mission and reflects collective dedication to achieving impactful goals.

Looking onward, the WBF remains steadfast in its mission. WBF is committed to supporting initiatives that bridge divides, cultivate peace, and advance the integration and prosperity of the Western Balkans. Equipped with comprehensive data, WBF is constructing a compelling narrative of the tangible change achievable through unified pursuit of shared objectives.

Crosscutting issues of WBF grants

Green Agenda

Regional Outreach

Gender Sensivity

Conflict Sensitivities

Knowledge Sharing

Marginalized Groups

Freedom of Expression

EU Integration

Reconciliation

Innovation & Digitalisation



THE LESSONS THAT WE LEARNED

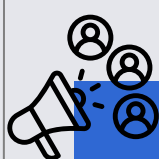
One of the grantees of the 6th Call for Proposals is rediscovering and promoting the works of the famous architect, Bogdan Bogdanovic. The monuments he erected are spread all over former Yugoslavia

- 
- Priority areas in our focus, such as culture and art, education and research, and sustainable development, remain a key source of reconciliation through many established regional cooperations and people-to-people initiatives.
 - Based on the data collected, WBF has learned that building a better region aligns with the broader EU integration process, a key objective shared by all our Contracting Parties.
 - The interest in applying for financing from the Civil Society Organisations of the region is growing.
 - Despite the constant increase in our funding, the need greatly surpasses the available resources. On average, we are able to finance little more than one-tenth of the proposals that we receive.
 - Over time, our portfolio of projects has greatly expanded and diversified, including cross-cutting issues such as gender sensitivity, conflict sensitivity, freedom of expression, empowerment of marginalized groups, innovation, digitalization, the green agenda, etc.



THE IMPORTANCE OF ADAPTABILITY AND RESPONSIVENESS

Adapting to changing circumstances and being responsive to the needs of stakeholders has proven crucial in driving regional cooperation. Our flexibility in program implementation allowed us to address emerging challenges effectively.



STAKEHOLDER ENGAGEMENT REMAINS CRITICAL

Continuous and meaningful engagement with stakeholders, including governments, civil society organizations, and the general public, is essential for us. This engagement not only enhances program effectiveness but also builds widespread support and trust in our initiatives.



EFFECTIVE MONITORING AND EVALUATION

Rigorous monitoring and evaluation of granted projects are imperative in demonstrating progress and ensuring accountability. Implementing a robust Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning (MEL) system has helped us make data-driven decisions and improve our programs continuously.



DIVERSIFICATION OF GRANT SCHEMES

Diversifying our grant portfolio has allowed us to address various regional needs more comprehensively. The introduction of different grant schemes, such as the MOVE Grant Scheme and Empowering Regional Cooperation Grants, has shown our commitment to sustainable regional cooperation.



CAPACITY BUILDING AND MENTORSHIP

Providing capacity-building support and mentorship to grantees enhances the effectiveness and sustainability of their projects. This approach has led to significant improvements in grant-making procedures and project outcomes.



PUBLIC PERCEPTION AND TRUST

Assessing and addressing public perceptions towards regional cooperation and good neighborly relations is crucial. Positive shifts in public attitudes, as evidenced by surveys and community dialogues, indicate progress in overcoming historical prejudices and fostering trust among communities.



ADVOCACY AND VISIBILITY AND EVALUATION

Advocacy actions and increased visibility through initiatives like the big international conferences which are essential for promoting our mission and achievements. These efforts have helped raise awareness and support for regional cooperation efforts.



OPERATIONAL EXCELLENCE AND ACCOUNTABILITY

Continuous improvements in operational processes, human resources, and digitalization efforts highlight our commitment to excellence and accountability; streamlined procedures and enhanced capabilities have been key to our growth and success.



COLLABORATION WITH LIKE- MINDED ORGANIZATIONS

Active engagement and collaboration with like-minded organizations have been beneficial by jointly implementing advocacy actions and capacity-building initiatives have amplified our impact and reach.

Homemade, regionally owned mechanism under the Chairmanship of **Sarajevo 24'**



ED Murra at the Celebrating Sarajevo Chairmanship-in-Office in Sarajevo (March 2024)

Forty years have elapsed since Sarajevo captivated the world as the host city of the 1984 Winter Olympics, an event of unparalleled magnitude in WB region's history.

While replicating such a spectacle may prove challenging, Sarajevo finds itself once more at the forefront of regional decision-making by taking over the Chairmanship-in-Office of the Western Balkans Fund.

The official commencement of this role was marked in March during a significant event at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Bosnia and Herzegovina

Deputy Minister of Foreign Affairs, Mr. Josip Brkić, hosted the occasion, which was attended by Dr. Gjergj Murra, Executive Director, alongside representatives from the Council of Senior Officials of the Fund.

The event also drew participation from civil society organizations, members of the diplomatic corps, including ambassadors and heads of missions from EU member states and Fund contracting parties like Japan, Switzerland, and Norway.

Additionally, the Head of the EU Delegation to BiH and representatives from various international organizations were present, emphasizing the importance of this milestone for regional cooperation and integration efforts.

During the Reporting period WBF has passed through two chairmanships: Tirana 2023 Chairmanship-in-Office and Sarajevo 2024 Chairmanship-in-Office



From the CSO Meeting in Brussels, March 2024



ED Murra and Deputy Foreign Minister of Bosnia and Herzegovina, H.E. Brkić

In his remarks, Deputy Minister Mr. Brkić highlighted the significance of the event in enhancing visibility for the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) and familiarizing Bosnian civil society organizations and youth with its mission and funding opportunities.

As Bosnia and Herzegovina is leading the chairmanship of the WBF in 2024, Deputy Minister Brkić emphasized the country's commitment to showcasing the Fund's importance on the global stage.

Dr. Murra, the Fund's Director, presented WBF's achievements and outlined future directions, highlighting the region's shared challenges and the potential for further collaboration. Representatives of Bosnian civil society organizations, previous recipients of WBF grants, shared success stories and showcased projects funded through the initiative.

The event concluded with Deputy Minister Brkić awarding grant certificates to Bosnian civil society representatives whose projects were selected in the latest WBF call for proposals, highlighting the Fund's role in supporting impactful initiatives within Bosnia and Herzegovina.

Emphasizing the Regional Ownership of the Fund



Committee of Senior Officials in Brussels
Meeting with DG Near high officials

WBF Statute underlines that the Council of Senior Officials is formed by the Ministries of Foreign Affairs of the Contracting Parties. They act as a supervisory and decision-making body on which the WBF relies for guidance, legitimacy, and approval.

Since the last Annual Report, published in September 2023, the Council has convened for three meetings: in September 2023, December 2023, and April 2024.

CSO Meeting of September 2023

The focus of this meeting was on the ongoing and future grant schemes that we unveiled in the coming months. Additionally, the CSO members discussed how to better sustain the growth of the Fund and continue enhancing regional cooperation among our stakeholders. As a sign of gratitude, the CSOs launched the Call of the WBF Move Grants.

Finally, Ambassador Ilir Melo, one of the longest-serving members of this board, was presented with a token of appreciation for his outstanding contribution towards the growth of the Fund.

CSO Meeting of December 2023

The December meeting marked the official passing of the Chairmanship-in-Office from the Tirana 2023 Chairmanship-in-Office to the Sarajevo 2024 Chairmanship-in-Office.

It reviewed the work of the last trimester of the year, the progress of the projects of the 6th Call for Proposals, and approved the WBF budget for 2024.

CSO Meeting of April 2024

Taking place in Brussels, the WBF Committee of Senior Officials convened at the Permanent Mission of Bosnia and Herzegovina to the European Union. This crucial meeting, merged with a keynote encounter with high EU Officials from the DG Near Department of the European Commission, seized the opportunity to review activities and accomplishments from January to April and strategize for the crucial months ahead.

Additionally, the CSO members discussed how to better sustain the growth of the Fund and continue enhancing regional cooperation among our stakeholders.



Previous CSO Meetings in 2023



Committee of Senior Officials, December 23



"VerityCon - Navigating the Disinformation Era" united in Tirana over 120 leaders, experts, journalists, activists and members of the diplomatic corps

A successful year under Tirana 2023 leadership

Before Sarajevo 2024 taking over the Chairmanship of the Fund, following the annual rotating mechanism, the Western Balkans Fund was led by the Tirana 2023 Chairmanship-in-Office. Under the leadership of Tirana CiO, in January 2023, Albania's Minister of Foreign Affairs and Europe, Ms. Xhaçka, articulated three key priorities for the Fund: strengthening institutional frameworks, enhancing regional and international visibility, and deepening cooperation with existing partners.

Throughout 2023, the Tirana CiO of the WBF diligently pursued these objectives, engaging in significant actions such as delivering a keynote speech at the Unstoppable Conference in February 2023 and participating in VerityCON in November 2023. Additionally, the CiO hosted a workshop in December 2023 focused on "Advancing Capacities for Regional Cooperation Champions in the Western Balkans."

The opportunities that we provide

The grants distributed by WBF are intrinsically linked to the organization's broader mission of promoting integration and cooperation in the Western Balkans. Through financial support, WBF empowers local organizations, civil society groups, and institutions to implement projects that align with its goals of fostering democratic values, economic prosperity, and social cohesion. By enabling these entities to carry out impactful work, WBF ensures that its mission is actualized on the ground, contributing to a more connected, resilient, and thriving region. This grant-making strategy is essential for achieving the organization's vision of a peaceful, cooperative, and forward-looking Western Balkans.

In the reporting period, we have been providing support through:

- **ERC Grants SCHEME**, co-funded by the European Union, is our largest scheme supporting Civil Society Organisations with grants of up to 30.000 EUR
- **The Sixth Call for Proposals**, funded entirely by the WBF core budget and supporting Civil Society Organisations of the WB Region with grants of up to 15.000 EUR
- **WBF Move Grants**, funded by the Swiss Agency for Development and Cooperation as part of the support towards the institutional strengthening of the WBF, supporting individual exchanges and mobilities with grants of up to 5.000 EUR
- **Western Balkans-Visegrad Fellowship**, run in cooperation with the International Visegrad Fund, supporting the mobility of scholars, researchers and lecturers of our two Regions

Art is food for the spirit. But art is also a cure for Mental Health Disabilities. Innovative therapies based on art are making a big change to so many, thanks to the wonderful work of our grantees, Association Tavan in Sarajevo and partners; Udruženje Prostor in Belgrade, Slišanje Glasov in Ljubljana and Dom Turnic in Rijeka.

Teaming Up for a better Region:

WBF-EU Joint Action



WBF Team at the EU Fair in Tirana

The European Union is a key strategic partner of the Western Balkans Fund. Our cooperation started back in 2021, in the framework of the project “Support to the Promotion of Civil Society regional actions in the Western Balkans (CN 424-879), otherwise known as the WBF-EU Joint Action.

Joint Action Phase I - From July 21 to January 24, during the implementation of the Joint Action I, WBF managed to support financially 69 CSOs in project implementation. Within the framework the grant scheme implemented through two Calls for Proposal implemented

within the EU/WBF Joint Action, 374 project applications, with 1,365 organizations participating in this Call as a lead-applicant or as the project partner, collectively giving an average number of partners per project of 3.64.

The complementary support to grants, the WBF provided mentoring support to grantees by combining online and onsite methods, with a focus on several areas such as: Financial and Procurement Procedures Training, Online Grant Management System Training, and onsite visits that were focused Project Management and Reporting.

In addition, WBF used the opportunity not only to monitor grantees through onsite visits but also represent the Fund in important events and collect immediate feedback on potential issues and overall project implementation progress

Joint Action Phase II - The WBF Secretariat managed to successfully complete all contractual documents and commence with the implementation of the second phase of the EU/WBF Joint Action in January 2024.

Within the framework of the EU/WBF Joint Action second phase were introduced two new pillars Empowering Regional Cooperation Grants (or according to the WBF Strategy are known as strategic grants) and Regional Dialogue sessions which will be conducted in all capitals during the project lifespan.

It is expected that implementation of the second phase to be completed in January 2026. With the continuation of the WBF will continue contributing to strengthening the cooperation and capacity development of the Civil Society Organizations and grass-root organizations in our region and strengthening participatory democracies in the Western Balkans region by connecting people from the region around CSO joint actions.



Background of a Strategic Partnership

Based on the commitments deriving from the Sofia 2018 Declaration and the 2019 Poznan Summit, the Fund strengthened the cooperation with European Union Commission with the purpose of supporting and promoting projects and initiatives that enhance regional cooperation, contribute to the sustainable development of the Western Balkans, and strengthen the bonds between the people of the region.

As a result, In 12 July 2021, the Fund concluded the cooperation agreement with EU Commission by signing the contract for the WBF/EU Joint Action to foster regional cooperation and contribute to the development of the Western Balkans.

Key dates of WBF-EU cooperation

May 2018 - Sofia EU-WB Declaration
July 2019 - WB Poznan Summit
July 2021 - WBF-EU agreement signed
November 2021 - Official launch of the WBF-EU Joint Action and launching of the First Join Call for Proposals
April 2022 - Awarding Ceremony, 1 CFP of the Joint Action
May 2022 - Launch of the 2 CFP for Proposals
19 December 2022 - Awarding Ceremony, 2 CFP of the Join Action
November 2023 - Agreement for Joint Action Phase II signed
January 2024 - End of the First Phase of the Joint Action. Start of the Second Phase
May 2024 - Launch of the Empowering Regional Cooperation Grants

Areas of Intervention of the ERC Grants

Economic Development & Innovation

Projects within this area of intervention shall focus on promoting sustainable economic growth, entrepreneurship, job creation, and investment in key sectors of the economy. These projects should incorporate sustainable practices and technologies, promoting green growth and environmentally friendly economic activities.

Social Inclusion and Human Rights

Projects within this area of intervention shall focus on addressing social disparities, promote equal opportunities, protect human rights, and support marginalized and vulnerable groups, including minorities, refugees, and persons with disabilities. These projects can include initiatives to address environmental justice, ensuring that marginalized and vulnerable groups have access to clean environments and are not disproportionately affected by environmental issues

Peacebuilding and Reconciliation

Projects within this area of intervention shall focus to the promotion of reconciliation, inter-cultural dialogue, and understanding among different communities and contribute to the peaceful resolution of conflicts in the Western Balkans region in order to create an environment conducive to collaborative efforts on environmental issues as well.

Empowering Regional Cooperation Grants - In Spring 2024, WBF launched ERC Call for Proposal with financial envelop in the amount of 350,000 EUR.

To keep the balanced approach, WBF foresaw awarding 12 projects in the amount of up to 30,000 EUR per project from six Contracting Parties with a project implementation timeline of seven months maximum with potential two months of no-cost extension.

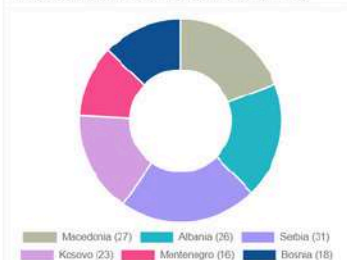
The launch of the ERC Grants coincided with Europe Day 2024. It was a very important and proud moment for the Western Balkans Fund because, with a grant size of 20-30.000 Euros, this is the largest Call for Proposals to have been ever launched by the WBF.

The ERC Call for Proposals remained opened from 9 May to 20 June 2024. In total, 289 organisations initiated an application, with 141 of them submitting a complete and final application.

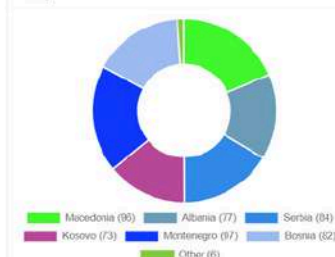
ERC in numbers

141 Submitted Projects
289 Total Projects
670 Participating CSOs

Submitted Application By Contracting Party



Application By No. of Patners Per Contracting Party





Regional Tour of Info Sessions

From 20-23 May 2024, different teams of the Western Balkans Fund have been travelling all over the Region, meeting with potential applicants of our newest and most ambitious scheme to date.

Our Regional Tour kicked off with Tirana and Podgorica Info Sessions on 20 May. WBF landed on Skopje and Prishtina the next day, followed by Sarajevo on 22 and Belgrade on 23.

+600

Over 600 participants of Civil Society Organisations and other eligible stakeholders attended our Regional Informative Sessions in the capitals of the Western Balkans Region or one of the many Online Info Sessions provided in English, as well as all the official languages of the Region.

WBF **Annual Call** for Proposals: Already making a difference

On 17 November 2023, Western Balkans Fund successfully launched the Sixth Call for Proposals, on 17 November 2023 with a deadline for submission of Project Proposals 27 December 2023.

WBF received a total number of 279 complete project applications, out of which 181 were by new applicants.

The overall number of created applications in the Online Grant Management System was 491, out of which 212 were not submitted, while the percentage of all filled sections within the application form was 9.81% (624 out of 6360).

753

Participating
organisations

3.105.605

Of Euros, total
amount requested

279

Eligible Applicants

491

Total Applicants

More than 600 organizations participated in this Call as a lead-applicant and/or as the project partner, collectively giving an average number of partners per project of 3.7.

1:10

Ratio of Supported
Applicants vs Applicants

Based on project applications received it must be highlighted that around 3 in 5 project proposals, are led by organizations applying for the first time in the WBF grant scheme, while 1 in 3, have been involved in the past, and only 46 applicants have been awarded in one of WBF's previous calls.

In terms of maturity and experience of organizations, around 40% of applicants consider themselves grassroots organizations.

Regarding the areas of intervention, Education Exchange, and Scientific Exchange (33%) remains as primary area of intervention, while second place is taken by Cultural Cooperation (23%) followed by Sustainable Development (21%).

To assist applicants to find suitable Project Partners in the context of the preparation of this Call for Proposals, the WBF has established a Partnership Platform in Facebook.

The eligible project proposals from all Contracting parties, except Podgorica, typically involved 2 partners based on their median values. However, -project proposals from Podgorica tended to have 3 partners on average (both median and mode values).

Overall, there were 664 partners involved, with project proposals from Sarajevo and Skopje requiring the highest number of partners.

The overall financial support requested by the applicants from the Western Balkans Fund was 2,304,929 Euros, with total project budget reaching approximately 3.1 million Euros.

With a maximal amount of 320.000 Euros allocated for the 6th Call for Proposal, the amount requested from the applicants surpasses the actual budget by approximately five times.



WBF-funded International Congress of Healthcare Professionals in Prishtina

WBF **Move Grants** enhancing mobility all over the Region

WBF MOVE Grant Mechanism is a unique opportunity for all citizens of the Western Balkans to apply and be awarded a grant for Mobility activities in the region.

WBF MOVE Grants has been launched in March 2023, and after one year of full implementation it has proved a very successful and flexible, connecting may grantees from all six Contracting Parties coming from a wide range of field of interests such as: education, culture, economic development and digitalization, environment, etc..

Considering the period June 2023 – June 2024, WBF MOVE Grants have supported 89 projects which have

521

Total Applicants
(all four Calls combined)

have largely contributed to bringing people together, establishing new partnerships, creating new synergies and regional project ideas.

4

Call for Proposals
(3 of them in the Reporting period)

7

Different Fields
of Intervention

140

Total Winners

67%

Ratio of Women against
Total Winners



Aida Glavinic, a WB-F-Move Grantee

What commonly stands out from WB-F MOVE Grantees is the enthusiasm and the passion each one of them clearly shows by using MOVE as a tool to bring positive change with their ideas and projects.

In a nutshell, this article presents the data of WB-F MOVE for June 2023-June 2024 which includes the implementation of three grant schemes.

WB-F MOVE Grants have significantly complemented the other WB-F Programs by reinforcing its presence in the whole region and increasing especially the participation of applicants from the non-capital areas.

Another important data is that, among MOVE applicants, there is 53-47% gender balance, whereas among MOVE Grantees 67%

are women, ensuring a great participation of women from different fields of interest in regional mobility actions.

Regarding fields of intervention, there is a high interest for at least three, respectively: Culture, Education and scientific research and economic development and digitalization. Nevertheless, all fields of interest which are available for WB-F MOVE Grants have been addressed, showing the flexibility and the wide range of activities that MOVE can support.

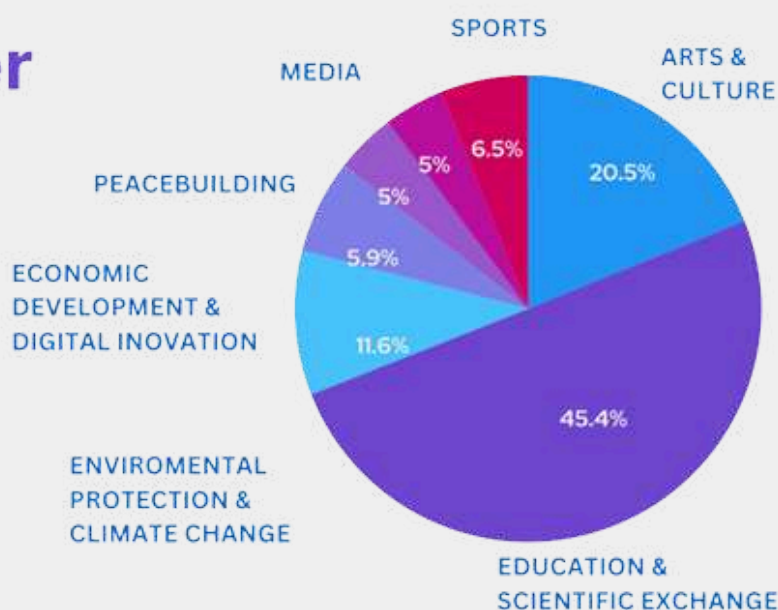
Feedback from MOVE Grantee show that there is great appreciation in the way WB-F manages its grant programs, as it ensures dedicated staff for each Contracting Party, facilitating language barriers, implementation hurdles and giving hands on mentoring session in order to make sure grantees have all information necessary for a successful management of the MOVE projects.

Projects as per area of intervention (applications)

Our beneficiaries range from:

- Researchers
- Students
- Professors
- Journalists
- Actors
- Artists
- Musicians
- Activists
- Experts
- Doctors

...



Feedback from MOVE Grantee show that there is great appreciation in the way WBF manages its grant programs, as it ensures dedicated staff for each Contracting Party, facilitating language barriers, implementation hurdles and giving hands on mentoring session in order to make sure grantees have all information necessary for a successful management of the MOVE projects.

One outstanding result that has been noticed during the implementation of MOVE is that individuals show a high sense of responsibility and dedication in successfully implementing their projects, considering it also as a valuable experience in further applying for bigger funds.

2023 was an outstanding year for WBF MOVE Grants as three WBF MOVE Call for Proposals were launched supporting in total 111 projects.

Based on lessons learned and data analysis from the first pilot year of MOVE, it has been assessed that for 2024 it is more efficient to open two MOVE calls dedicated to individuals, in early Spring and early Autumn.

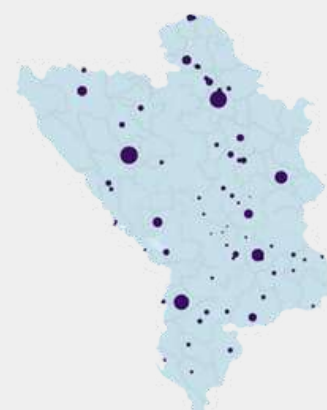
We are looking forward to this year MOVE Projects as we are already seeing great ideas coming into life exceptionally led by citizens of the Western Balkans Fund.

Start thinking about your next move in our region!

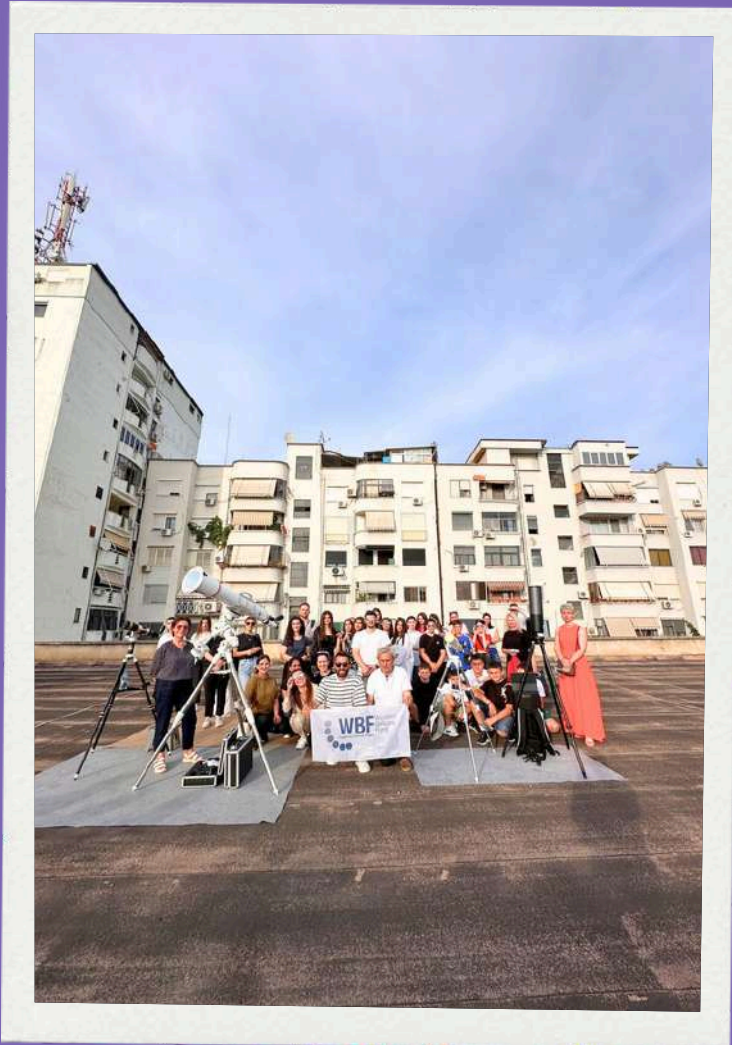
Heat map



GEOGRAPHICAL SPREAD
34% of applicants are coming from non-capitals







Western Balkans - Visegrad Fellowship

The International Visegrad Fund (IVF) and the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) joined hands in March for the support of the academia community of both regions.

The Visegrad Group is well known for its long-standing commitment to V4+WB6 cooperation, aiming to support the stability, development and European perspective of the Western Balkans.

For the first time in 2024, The Western Balkans Fund and the International Visegrad Fund jointly launched a call to support Western-Balkans – Visegrad Fellowships for PHD holders or PHD candidates of both regions.

This grant scheme is a unique opportunity for the academic community of both V4 and WB regions to further strengthen partnerships, advance research and exchange opportunities.

The Fellowship Program will follow the model of Visegrad Fellowships which have been implemented since 2023 in the V4 region and shall be jointly coordinated by the Western Balkans Fund and the International Visegrad Fund (both hereinafter as “donors”).

The Fellowships, launched in 15 April 2024, shall offer funding for individual short-term stays for V4 and WB6 scholars, lecturers, and researchers in two main directions—citizens of Czechia, Hungary, Poland, and Slovakia will be able to apply to relevant host institutions in Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Montenegro, North Macedonia, Kosovo, or Serbia, and citizens of Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, Montenegro, North Macedonia, Kosovo, or Serbia will be able to apply to relevant host institutions in V4 countries.

The financial allocation for the 2024 pilot stage is max. €40,000 from the WBF and max. €60,000 from the IVF. The WBF financial portfolio will cover projects coming from the V4 region and the IVF financial portfolio will cover the ones coming from the WB6 region.

154 Fellowship Applications

First Call of the new Fellowship pilot scheme attracted a high number of scholars from both our Region. The implementation starts in September 2024



Signature of the Western Balkans - Visegrad Fellowship Agreement between the Executive Directors in Bratislava, 6 March 2024



Building Capacities and Trust

- Mentoring and Partnership workshops
- WBF-AICS joint capacity-building program
- Monitoring and Learning
- Driving innovative approaches
- Accountability and Transparency
- Providing constant opportunities to grow

Back in 2019, Wines of Macedonia approached our fund with an ambitious idea: to create a Balkan Wine Network, bringing together wineries from all across the Western Balkans region. Recognizing the immense potential of this project, we decided to support their vision, giving it the name "Wines as a Bridge of Cooperation in the Western Balkans Region." Today, "Balkan Wines" has grown to become an umbrella organisation of over 100 Western Balkans Wine producers, exporting the typical wines of our Region all over the World. Picture, from the Wine tasting tour of "Balkan Wines" near Kavadarci, North Macedonia

Mentoring & Monitoring Supporting the growth of our grantees & partners



The Western Balkans Fund is much more than just a grant-giving organisation.

We have already become a hub, that support the growth of grassroots and Civil Society organisation in the Region.

WBF has implemented a robust mentoring support system for its grantees, starting from the application stage through project implementation.

This support includes project management, financial and procurement procedures, Reporting, and the use of the Online Grant Management System.

This mentoring has significantly impacted grantees' capacities to engage in regional cooperation and address regional cohesion and reconciliation issues.

Furthermore, to expand the elements of Monitoring and Mentoring, WBF has taken several strategic measures.

The organization has strengthened its monitoring framework by incorporating advanced data collection and analysis tools. We have also added a new grante portal, tailor-made and dedicated to all grantees of the Fund.

This technological enhancement allows for more informed decision-making and more effective resource allocation.

Additionally, WBF has established structured mentoring programs, pairing experienced professionals and our experts with the representatives of the Civil Society in the Region and activists.

Furthermore, we are actively organizing significant capacity-building events, such as the 3-day training for CSOs organized jointly with EU TACSO last December in Durres.

We are also proud of being able to monitor and support, often in person, all our grantees from the recent Call for Proposals.

By investing in these areas, WBF ensures that its initiatives not only achieve their immediate objectives but also contribute to the long-term development and stability of the Western Balkans.

OF GRANTEES REPORTED AN EXCELLENT LEVEL OF COOPERATION WITH WBF

GRANTEES FOUND MENTORING SUPPORT BENEFICIAL, PARTICULARLY IN FINANCIAL MANAGEMENT, REPORTING, VISIBILITY, REGIONAL COOPERATION, AND PARTNER COMMUNICATION.

GRANTEES THAT USED MENTORING SUPPORT STATED THAT MENTORING POSITIVELY IMPACTED THEIR CAPACITIES FOR REGIONAL COOPERATION AND ADDRESSING REGIONAL COHESION /RECONCILIATION ISSUES.



Together with the Italian Agency for Cooperation and Development (AICS) to build capacities in the WB

On 3d of June 2024, the Western Balkans Fund signed a new project with the Italian Agency for Development and Cooperation for the Western Balkans.

This first cooperation with such an important regional partner comes an effort to join forces for better contributing to a more cohesive and vibrant region.

The project is entitled “Development of Capacity Building Programs for Cultural and Creative Industries in the Western Balkans Fund” and is implemented in the framework of the EU-funded project “Culture and creativity for the Western Balkans - CC4WBs”.

Culture and Creativity is part of one of the main fields of interventions of the Western Balkans Fund, and this action will give WBF the opportunity to increase its presence and contribute to supporting culture and creativity furthermore in all six Contracting Parties.



Signature of the agreement between ED Murra and the head of AICS for the Balkans, Ms. Vizzaccaro



The first workshops in Tirana and Prishtina



The objective of the project is to enhance Cultural and Creative operators' skills in the region to increase their fundraising efforts and improve performance in project management skills for better implementing regional projects. This objective is in complete synergy and in line with the objectives of WBF Strategic plan 2020-2024, as it builds productive partnerships with like-minded organizations in the region and ensures promotion, visibility, and advocacy for regional cooperation.

The activities foreseen by the project fall within WBF scope of work to ensure capacity building and mentoring for grantees and other relevant actors in the region, enhancing their performance in building partnerships, implementing regional projects contributing to a more vibrant society.

The first workshops under this cooperation scheme started in July 2024.

Championing resilience and excellence through data-driven policies



Monitoring and Learning (MEL) is a critical component for the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) as it ensures that the organization's activities and initiatives are aligned with its strategic objectives and deliver measurable impacts.

Benefiting from a six years long partnership with Peace Nexus, we have put in place a strong MEL framework, with dozens of different elements, that allow WBF to make data-driven decisions aiming to optimize our current decision-making.

By embedding MEL practices, WBF not only ensures accountability to its stakeholders but also fosters a culture of continuous improvement and learning within the organization. This approach enables WBF to identify best practices, address challenges proactively, and adapt to the dynamic socio-economic landscape of the Western Balkans.

To further expand the MEL element, WBF has implemented several key measures. Firstly, the organization has invested in capacity building for its staff, providing training and resources to enhance their skills in monitoring and evaluation.

This includes workshops, seminars, and collaborative learning sessions designed to build a strong MEL competency across the team.

Secondly, WBF has integrated advanced data collection and analysis tools into its operations, allowing for more precise and timely monitoring of project outcomes.

These tools facilitate real-time data tracking and enable the organization to generate comprehensive Reports that inform strategic decisions.

Moreover, WBF has fostered partnerships with local and international experts to leverage external insights and methodologies, ensuring that its MEL practices are aligned with global standards and best practices.

By collaborating with academic institutions, research organizations, and other development agencies, WBF continually enhances its MEL framework, making it more robust and adaptable.

These efforts demonstrate WBF's commitment to maximizing the impact of its initiatives and contributing to the sustainable development of the Western Balkans region.

Mapping next steps: Strategic planning for success



WBF Team Retreat in Ohrid

In June, against the magnificent backdrop of Ohrid Lake in the beautiful city of Ohrid, the WBF Secretariat gathered to plan the grant schemes that will be open in the fall.

It also discussed on how to improve our current MEL framework, how to introduce best practices in the financial management, how to improve WBF's outreach, etc.

Teaming-up with RAI and RESPA to enhance regional influence

Over the past year, the Western Balkans Fund (WBF) has significantly expanded its partnership with the Regional School of Public Administration (ReSPA) and the Regional Anti-Corruption Initiative (RAI). These collaborations have strengthened WBF's commitment to fostering regional cooperation and enhancing governance standards across the Western Balkans. By working closely with ReSPA, WBF has promoted public administration reforms and capacity building, while the partnership with RAI has focused on advancing anti-corruption measures and transparency initiatives.

Innovation & Digitalisation

Do you know

All applications and project management at WBF is done through our wbf portal, enhancing transparency and greatly facilitating application and management



From the meetings with the technical experts aiming to enhance digitalisation and transparency

For the first three Calls for Proposals, the applicant had to email or mail their applications by post. After collecting all applications with the evaluations manually, the Secretariat proceeded to select the best 18 or 24 projects out of hundreds of applications.

This approach was time-consuming for our applicants and the Secretariat staff. We began a big innovation undertaking to address this issue, fully digitalizing the application system.

In line with this progress, the WBF Applicant Portal was introduced during the 4th Call, serving as the primary tool for applying to WBF Calls. The digitalization of grant applications has had a transformative impact, revolutionizing the process to enhance efficiency, accessibility, and transparency.

This shift to digital platforms has empowered a more comprehensive range of applicants, simplified operations, and fostered collaboration.

By embracing these digital tools, grant-makers and applicants have benefited from a more effective and inclusive grant ecosystem.

This advancement has led to a reduction in paperwork, improved accessibility, and a user-friendly system. Furthermore, it is now much easier to stay updated on the status of applications after submission.

Building on this success, WBF, in collaboration with the GoEasy Team, developed the WBF Grantee Portal that became fully functional in the Reporting period of this Annual Report.

This new digital mechanism enables the collection of relevant data on project implementation, facilitates progress monitoring of activities, and streamlines financial and narrative Reporting for the projects funded through the WBF 5th Call.

The WBF Grantee Portal represents a significant step forward in optimizing the grantee experience and ensuring effective project management.

The push towards modernisation has brought tangible benefits to the Fund. Thanks to the Development of the OGMS:

The number of ineligible applications has dropped immediately with the implementation of the system.

In the last two annual Calls for Proposals, the number fell to 3% and 2% respectively. The average rate of ineligible applications before the implementation of this system was 11%, with the highest being 14% of the total number of applicants.

The Fund is able to follow the trends live and online. This enables us to take real-time decisions that enhances our regional outreach, making possible to focus on areas that have not been sufficiently represented. Through this approach, we can provide a better distribution of our grants.

We have also worked and enhanced the experience of our homepage, with the aim of increasing the user-friendliness of the Fund. Successful efforts were made to ensure a right indexing of the WBF at the search engines.

Last, but not least, WBF Team is currently working to build a “search engine” of its own, in turning the partnership match-making platform of “WBF Partnership” on Facebook, in a large web and app enhancing the creation of partnerships in the Region.



Accountability and Transparency: WBF operational model

Ensuring responsible financial management, transparency, accountability and sustainability in all the Fund’s activities is our main objective. Throughout the year, we have maintained meticulous records in compliance with our financial regulations to uphold the highest standards of financial integrity. The Fund remains committed to effectively allocating resources towards our mission-driven programs, maximize impact and build trust among our stakeholders.

Financial Audit for the year 2023

During the period of March and April 2024, WBF conducted the audit of financial statements for the year 2023.

This important process was performed by the independent auditor UHY Elite.

UHY Elite is one of the top 20 biggest accounting firms in Albania and is a full member of UHY International which is among 20 firms of the world’s leading business advisory, consulting and accounting networks, with teams operating across nearly 300 offices in 100 countries worldwide.

WBF emphasizes the importance of this process, which provides assurance for the shareholders that the financial statements are presented accurately and aligned with all applicable regulations and standards.

Below is presented the opinion of the independent auditor:

Western Balkans Fund revenue 2023-24



Breakdown of WBF revenue for 2023-24 (fiscal year 23' and 24 combined)

Contracting Parties	1.080.000
European Commission	667.930
Swiss Development and Cooperation	257.005
Japan Embassy	106.000
Italian Agency for Development Cooperation	75.000
International Visegrad Fund	40.000
Peace Nexus	9.626



UHY Elite sh.p.k
NIPT K31712103L
Rr. "Ibrahim Rugova"
Pallati 17 H3, Apt. 12 Tirana, Albania
Tel. Fax +355 4 2237199
e-mail: info@uhy-elite.com
www.uhy-elite.com

INDEPENDENT AUDITOR'S REPORT

To the Executive Director and Conference of Ministers of Foreign Affairs of Western Balkan Fund

Opinion

We have audited the statement of financial position of Western Balkan Fund ("The Organization") which comprise the financial position on 31 December 2023, the statement of activities and the statement of cash flows for the year then ended and notes to the financial statements, including a summary of significant accounting policies.

In our opinion, the accompanying financial statements of Western Balkan Fund on 31 December 2023, are prepared in all material respects in accordance with the Modified cash basis of accounting as described in Note 2.

Tirana
Date 30 April 2024



Creating shared value through our internship programme

The WBF Internship Program provides a valuable opportunity for youth empowerment in the Western Balkans. Supported by the International Visegrad Fund, the program offers a three-week internship at the WBF Secretariat, focusing on grant management and public relations.

Participants gain professional development and regional networking, fostering mutual experiences, values, traditions, and culture.

This program promotes good neighbourly relations and enhances knowledge about regional cooperation and the specific objectives of the WBF.

WBF hosted 2 interns from the WB6 region at its Secretariat between December 2023 and July 2024. The interns, Helena Plaku from Tirana and Emin Kurtanovic from Sarajevo were selected through an open call process.



They demonstrated strong motivation to work in the field of regional cooperation and had diverse academic backgrounds with international experience.

It is worth noting that since its establishment, WBF has provided internship opportunities to a total of 12 individuals at its Secretariat.

During their time at the WBF Secretariat, the interns had the valuable opportunity to enhance their understanding and knowledge in various cross-cutting areas.

These included, but were not limited to, reconciliation, promoting good neighborly relations, advancing gender equality, empowering youth, fostering cross-border cooperation, and supporting European integration efforts.

Through their engagement with WBF projects and activities, the interns gained practical insights and hands-on experience in these important fields of regional cooperation.

The development curriculum focused on key skills and qualities essential for success, including collaboration, leadership, integrative thinking, and innovation.

Through a combination of hands-on experiences, interactive workshops, mentorship, and learning resources, interns were encouraged to cultivate these skills and foster a culture of continuous learning.



Emin Kurtanovic



Katarina Konatar



Katarina Popovic



Rita Zhubi

NETWORKING

- PR activities - Expanding Regional Outreach
- Building bridges: Cooperation with like-minded partners



FUJIFILM

Enhancing the visibility of our mission



Dafina Beqiri (second from left), Senior Program Manager releases an interview at Top Albania Radio

Promoting regional cooperation is a crucial component of our mission and daily work.

Visibility is very important for creating the de-facto solidarity that will support wide-scale cooperation and the reconciliation process in the Western Balkans region.

It is also a top priority for our contracting parties, who, since 2021, have made visibility a top priority in their agendas for the Western Balkans Fund.

In terms of visibility, June 2023 to June 2024 has been a very important year during which the Western Balkans Fund successfully expanded its regional outreach.

The communication strategy, aligned with the 2020-24 Strategic Development Plan, is based on five components: public events, info and monitoring sessions, representation visits, social and other media, and publications.

1.200.000

users followed the
Western Balkans
Fund channels of
communication

30.000

total followers in
the social media

185

articles published
in the webpage of
the Fund in the
Reporting period

+700

total posts in all
the communication
channels

+30%

general outreach
of WB channels
compared to the
same Reporting
period 22-23

During the Reporting period, one of the most important public events was the joint EU-TACSO workshop in December 2023 in Durrës, where over 50 important regional stakeholders gathered for three days.

Another important event was the participation of the Western Balkans Fund at the EU Fair, where a dedicated stand for the Fund generated significant interest from hundreds of citizens who engaged with our staff and inquired about the opportunities we provide.

The regional tour of info sessions in Autumn 2023 and Spring 2024 was also a very important tool to engage with our audience and potential beneficiaries in the Western Balkans region. In total, we held over 20 informative sessions, with opportunities to engage with us provided both online and in all the native languages of our contracting parties.

Partnership Platform

In addition to our communication channels, we pioneered a partnership platform that currently has 3,000 members on Facebook. The platform is a matching tool for organizations looking for new regional partners.

Social Media and Webpage

The Reporting period has been remarkable in terms of the growth of our social media communication channels and the webpage. Forty-eight thousand visitors (up from 13,000 last year) received direct information from our homepage, generating traffic of 359,000 actions, compared to 108,000 in the same Reporting phase last year.

On social media, our largest channel, Facebook, saw a total of 329 posts, reaching 518,000 accounts. On Instagram, another widely used platform by the Fund, the reach exceeded 100,000 (108,000 vs. 50,000 last year).

Significant increases were also noticed on Twitter, LinkedIn, and YouTube. Combined, the Western Balkans Fund has over 30,000 loyal followers on social media.

Regional Media

Public events, selected projects, and success stories have been featured in general media, including news portals, blogs, television, magazines, and radio. For the first time, the Fund has published content in selected channels controlled by the European Union. Our team has appeared on various TV and radio talk shows in all the contracting parties. Among the most influential media that have Reported on our Fund and stories are Radio Free Europe, N1 Network, Top Channel, We Balkans portal, etc.

WBF Representation and Networking

Since June 2023, WBF, on top of the numerous monitoring visits to the grants, throughout the region and info meetings has continued to put significant efforts to nurture its professional connections. Some of the most important meetings and promotional actions that occurred during the Reporting period are as follows:

2023

On June 1st, WBF Senior Programme Manager and EU Programme Manager was a speaker at the TACSO Meeting in Podgorica.

On 15-16 June, WBF ED attended the Prespa Forum Dialogue in Struga.

On June 20th WBF attended the 2023 Tirana CSF of the Western Balkans Summit Series.

On June 29th, WBF ED attended the "High-Level Cybersecurity Conference – Towards a resilient cyberspace in the Western Balkans" organized by the RCC in Brussels.

On August 17th, a WBF delegation, headed by the WBF ED met at the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of BiH with the Minister, H.E. Elmedin Konaković.



ED Murra meets the MFA of Bosnia and Hercegovina, H.E. Konakovic in Sarajevo



From Prespa Dialogue Forum, June 2023



Cybersecurity Conference in Brussels

On August 17, a WBF delegation visited the headquarters of the Regional Anti-Corruption Initiative - RAI;

On August 31, Ms Stefania Vizzaccaro, Director of Italian Cooperation and Development Agency for the Western Balkans Region paid a visit at the WBF secretariat premises.

On September 19, Ms. Gudrun Kramer - GiZ Program Manager in Sarajevo paid a visit at the WBF Secretariat premises.

On September 28th, Mr. Damir Dzanko, Acting Secretary of the Ministry of Foreign Affairs of Bosnia, and Herzegovina visited the Secretariat.

On October 12th, a delegation composed by over 30 students from North Macedonia paid a visit to the Secretariat Premises.

On October 2023 – 27th Annual Forum 2000 in Prague.

On October 2023, WBF ED participated in the Belgrade Security Forum

On October 21st, a delegation of over 20 students from Mathias Corvinus University in Budapest paid a visit to the Secretariat.

On November 2023, The WBF ED and IVF Executive Director signed a Memorandum of Understanding that strengthens the already excellent relationship.

On December 13th, Ms Fiona McCluney, United Nations Resident Coordinator for Albania paid a visit to WBF premises.



ED Murra greets Ms. McCluney, UN Resident Coordinator



Reception for AICS Director Vizzaccaro at the Secretariat



Welcoming of MPs from Skopje at the Secretariat



Mathias Corvinus University students at the Secretariat

2024

On February 5, the newly appointed Ambassador of Japan to Tirana, H.E. KATO Kikuko visited the Western Balkans Fund Secretariat Premises.

On February 6, WBF ED and team had a meeting with the German Ambassador to Tirana, H.E. Karl Bergner.

On February 21, WBF welcomed Mr. Beckmann-Dierkes, head of the Konrad Adenauer Foundation in Bulgaria and acting head of the Albanian foreign office.

On March 6, in Bratislava, WBF and IVF launched the joint Fellowship for PhD candidates, researchers, scholars, and academic staff.

On March 8th, ReSPA Director, Ms. Maja HANDJISKA-TRENDAFILOVA and her team visited the WBF Secretariat premises.

On March 12th WBF SPM participated at the Budapest Balkans Forum

On March 13th WBF ED and team attended the Event “Kick Off of the WBF B&H Chairmanship in Office in Sarajevo.

On March 13th, WBF ED, CiO and SO's of Belgrade and Tirana met with the Swiss Ambassador to Sarajevo, Mr. Daniel Hunn

On March 27th, WBF ED met with H.E. Ambassador of Switzerland in Albania, Robert Huth and other high officials at the premises of the Embassy.



ED Murra and the Japanese Ambassador to Tirana, H.E. Kato



Meeting with Ambassador Hunn and Committee of Senior Officials of the WBF in Sarajevo



German Ambassador visits the Secretariat



ED Murra and IVF ED Mares shaking hands in Bratislava

On April 16, SPM of the Western Balkans Fund attended the “Empower Local: Building Capacities for Western Balkans’ Local Governments on the EU Integration Journey” in Tirana! organized by ReSPA and supported by GiZ

On April 19th, the Executive Director of the WBF, accompanied by the Members of the Council of Senior Officials attended a meeting with high representatives of DG Near headquarters in Brussels.

On May 8th, WBF attended the dialogue on the future of Western Balkans, a dialogue initiated by the EU Ambassador to Tirana, H.E. Silvio Gonzato.

On May 8th, a delegation of students visited the Secretariat.

On May 9th, a team from the Fund participated in the EU Fair of Opportunities organised in Tirana.

On May 17th, the ED and the General Director of the AICS (Italian Agency for Cooperation and Development) signed a partnership agreement at the headquarters of AICS.

On May 28th, in Sarajevo, the WBF ED signed a MoU with Mreza Mira, a network for Civil Society Organisations in Bosnia and Herzegovina.

On June 12nd, in Skopje, the WBF ED participated in the Annual Meeting of the RCC.



GIZ Conference in April 16



WBF-EU encounter at the DG Near Headquarters in Brussels



Ambassador Gonzato at a Conference, 8 May 2024



With Mreza Mira, in Sarajevo, May 2024

LIST OF ANNUAL GRANTS

Portfolio of the 6th Annual Call for Proposals



Title: Ecological Business Sustainability

Partners: Serbian Association of Employers, Business Confederation of Macedonia, Montenegro Employers’ Federation

About: The overall objective is to contribute to the development of a Western Balkans single market, facilitating free and successful movement of workers, modeled after the European Union. This initiative aims to meet the accession requirements for Serbia, Montenegro, and North Macedonia, enhancing their ability to achieve sustainable development and promoting integration across the Western Balkans region as a whole.

Title: Empowering Rural Youth Organizations

Partners: Vision for Development and Cooperation, Liza R, NGO Zjate Doren, Municipality of Lushnja

About: The “Empowering Rural Youth Organizations” project focuses on enhancing the capabilities of youth organizations across the Western Balkans. It aims to cultivate essential skills in youth workers and leaders, promoting community engagement and regional collaboration.

The main events are under implementation in Presevo.

Title: Empowering Journalism Educators in the Western Balkans for Conflict & Crisis Reporting

Partners: Belgrade International Law Circle, Humanistic Studies of the University of Donja Gorica, Faculty of Political Sciences University of Sarajevo

About: This project aims to enhance crisis Reporting in the Western Balkans by providing journalism educators and professionals with specialized training and resources. It focuses on fostering accurate and responsible Reporting to support reconciliation and cooperation in the region.

Title: Serbia, Bosnia and Herzegovina and Montenegro Connected by Cultural Heritage and Art

Partners: Center for Research and Valorization of Architectural Heritage "VAM" (Center VAM), National Gallery of Bosnia and Herzegovina; Museum of Polimlje, Berane

About: The project celebrates the shared cultural heritage of the Western Balkans through the legacy of architect Bogdan Bogdanović. It aims to foster regional unity and a positive culture of remembrance through collaborative cultural and educational initiatives.



Title: Solar Schools for Green Transition

Partners: Friends of Korca Association, along with 9 partners from Bar, Debar, Belgrade, Korçë, Tirana, Malta

About: The project aims to unite students, high schools, and CSOs within the Western Balkans through the Network of Solar Schools. It focuses on delivering solar energy solutions and educational content to combat climate change and promote a green transition.

The project builds on the successful experience of the already implemented project of the 5th Call for Proposals.

Title: Educating and Empowering Families for LGBTIQ+ in Albania - I AM YOUR CHILD!

Partners: Open Mind Spectrum Albania (OMSA), CEL – Centre for Equality and Liberty, ERA - LGBTI Equal Rights Association for Western Balkans and Turkey

About: The initiative aims to create a supportive atmosphere for LGBTIQ+ individuals within their families, promoting inclusivity and acceptance in Western Balkans society.

It endeavors to educate and empower families, fostering understanding and respect for LGBTIQ+ rights.

Title: Women Transform the Balkans: Cultural Bridge of the Regional Network

Partners: Women's Museum Foundation, NVO NOVA Centar za feminističku kulturu, The Alliance of Feminist Organizations "(Re)connection"

About: The project aims to foster regional cooperation and dialogue in the Western Balkans through the establishment of a network dedicated to feminist discourse and broader societal issues. It seeks to unite diverse groups with the capacity to inspire change, encouraging a deeper understanding and collaboration across the region.

35% of the projects from the 6th Call for Proposals are addressing challenges related to environmental protection, either directly or indirectly

Title: Virtual Tour of 3 Castles

Partners: SEKTRA, Cultural Innovative Development Initiative's (CIDI), Makenski Centar na ITI

About: The project aims to create immersive virtual tours of the "Castle of Prizren," "Castle of Skopje," and "Castle of Lezha," enhancing cultural cooperation and education. It will offer interactive experiences that simulate physical visits, making historical exploration accessible to a wider audience.

Additionally, the initiative serves as a digital preservation effort, safeguarding the rich history of these significant sites for future generations.

Title: Eco Friendly Colony

Partners: Association for Development, Environment and Culture EKO ZH; NVO Our Action Montenegro; Environment Engineering Group

About: The Eco Friendly Colony project aims to bridge ethnic and geographical divides in the Western Balkans by fostering tolerance and cooperation among young artists through environmental and cultural activities.

The initiative also supports children with health challenges by donating art created at the Nature Park Blidinje in Bosnia and Herzegovina.

Title: Western Balkans Initiative on Tackling Informal Employment on Online Platforms

Partners: Center for Development Evaluation and Social Science Research; Public Policy Research Centre (CENTER); University Luigj Gurakuqi in Shkoder

About: This initiative aims to address informal employment on online platforms, promoting scientific exchange and education among partners from Albania, Bosnia and Herzegovina, and Serbia. It delves into the regulation of platform work, seeking to understand and mitigate the impacts of labour market informality in the region.



Cetinje Forum, April 2024



Art is food for the spirit. But art is also a cure for Mental Health Disabilities. Innovative therapies based on art are making a big change to so many, thanks to the wonderful work of our grantees, Association Tavan in Sarajevo and partners: Udruženje Prostor in Belgrade, Slišanje Glasov in Ljubljana and Dom Turnić in Rijeka.

Title: Enhancing Regional Cooperation in the field of Folklore

Partners: Ensemble of folk dances and songs "VESELIN MASLESA," Center of Traditional Culture and Art "Kosta Abrašević" Bačka Palanka, and Folklore Association "Igraorec" Skopje.

About: The project actively involves three Civil Society Organizations in the Western Balkans, promoting cultural cooperation through folk concerts, workshops, and traditional performances. Aligned with the WBF sixth Call for Proposals, it prioritizes good neighborly relations, people-to-people links, and reconciliation, addressing cross-cutting issues like gender equality, youth empowerment, social inclusion, and human rights.

Title: Soft and Hard Power Dynamics: Western Balkans Perspectives on Democracy, Education, and Security

Partners: Fakultet za crnogorski jezik i književnost; Regional Academy for Democratic Development ADD; Faculty of Political Science, University of Sarajevo

About: This project aims to enhance regional cooperation and cohesion in the Western Balkans through a Long-Term Cross-Cultural Dialogue Platform. It addresses the global crisis and counters populist rhetoric in politics, economics, academia, and culture. The annual Cetinje Forum serves as a cornerstone event, fostering dialogue, analyzing socio-cultural systems, and proposing methodologies for international cooperation, with the goal of strengthening regional cohesion.

Title: Acknowledging Contemporary Feminist and Queer Literature in the Western Balkans: Shtefica Cvek #3

Partners: Association for Creating Stories Naratorium; Pobunjene čitateljke; Coalition MARGINS

About: This project aims to combat dominant misogynist, patriarchal, and nationalist discourses in the post-Yugoslav public space by fostering a collaborative cultural environment. It promotes the experiences and voices of marginalized groups, including women, LGBTQI+, Roma people, workers, people with disabilities, the impoverished, and migrants.

Title: Culture Makes Us Unique

Partners: Kulturni Centar Stara Budva; Ansambl za narodni pesni i ora "Skopje"; Kulturno umjetničko društvo Abrašević Kraljevo, Serbia; Kulturno umjetničko društvo "Željezara", Zenica

About: This project aims to strengthen good neighborly relations and promote reconciliation among the Contracting Parties. By leveraging cultural connections, it seeks to overcome past political intolerance and foster mutual understanding, especially among young people. The initiative promotes social equality through cultural exchange, encouraging freedom of travel and employment opportunities in neighboring countries.

Title: Western Balkans Girls U13 Basketball Cup

Partners: Basketball Club Niksic; Basketball Club Vojvodina; Basketball Club Buducnost

About: This project aims to enhance regional and cross-border cooperation through a girls' basketball tournament. It seeks to improve regional collaboration among basketball clubs and promote gender equality in sports, while fostering reconciliation among Western Balkan countries. The tournament will also provide opportunities for young athletes to meet renowned coaches and players, further motivating them to participate in similar future events.

Title: Accursed Mountains - Cross Border Science Classroom II

Partners: NGO Green Home; Environmentally Responsible Action (ERA); Institute for Nature Conservation in Albania

About: This project aims to enhance good neighborly relations between the participating Contracting Parties by fostering cooperation, exchange, and education among students and future researchers on nature protection. Building on previous successes, it seeks to continue collaborative efforts through scientific and research exchange, with activities like the camp in Grebaja Valley.

Title: 2nd International Congress of Nursery

Partners: Chamber of Nurses and Midwives of Kosovo; The Order of the Nurse of Albania; Association of Albanian Nurses, Florence Nightingale

About: The 2nd International Congress of Nursery aims to establish a collaborative platform for knowledge exchange, interdisciplinary dialogue, and innovation among health professionals from the Western Balkans Region and beyond, including EU countries and USA. This initiative supports cross-border cooperation, sharing best practices, and addressing common challenges in healthcare.



International Conference of Chamber of Nurses in Prushtina, March 2024

Title: WB6 Young Jazz Musicians at Mitrovica International Jazz Days

Partners: Rona Nishliu Foundation; NGO: Umjetnost džeza-Jazz Art; CENTRE Albanian Jazz Society

About: This project aims to create a platform uniting young musicians and composers from the Western Balkans 6 (WB6) countries, utilizing jazz music to foster reconciliation, enhance neighborly relations, and strengthen regional cooperation.

The project culminates with the organisation of a large Festival, in which thousand of citizens are expected to attend.

Title: International Literary Festival: POLIP 2024 - Creative Writing Workshop

Partners: Multimetia Center in Prishtina; Center for Balkan Cooperation LOJA; Qendra "Kujri" (grupi ATA)

About: This project aims to bring together young and aspiring writers from partner countries and Kosovo to participate in a joint creative writing workshop in Prishtina, Kosovo, led by Pulitzer Prize winner Gregory Pardlo. The workshop seeks to support young writers' skills in creative writing and provide an international platform for them to showcase their work at the POLIP literary festival for young aspiring talents.

Title: MediaWISE - Digital Media Education as a Key Indicator in Students' Health and Well-being

Partners: Education Empowerment Initiative; Center for Excellence Destiny; Women in Science Network

About: The MediaWISE project employs a comprehensive approach the Contracting Parties, focusing on empowering 5th-grade students with digital literacy skills. It aims to cultivate critical thinking and resilience in navigating digital content, directly impacting student well-being. Additionally, it targets educators, schools, and surrounding communities to promote digital literacy and well-being.

polip

PRISHTINA
INTERNATIONAL
CREATIVE
HUB

17-19 MAY 2024

17 MAY FRIDAY
20:00-21:00 | ODA THEATER, PRISHTINA

POETIC
CONSULTATIONS
PERFORMANCE

A grid of 20 small portrait photos of diverse individuals, likely participants or artists associated with the POLIP festival. The photos are arranged in a 4x5 grid, with each person having a different background color.



Blidinje Nature Park, where will take place one of the projects of the 6 CFP

Title: Exploring Dimensions of Public Management, Policy, and Administration Across Diverse Sectors

Partners: Academic institutions from across the Western Balkans including South East European University, University of Sarajevo, University "Ismail Qemali" Vlore, University of Belgrade, Montenegro, and AAB College.

About: This regional conference fosters collaboration among academic institutions, policymakers, practitioners, and researchers to address critical issues in public administration, aiming to provide practical insights and promote effective governance strategies.

Title: Youth and Gambling

Partners: HOPS-Healthy Options Project Skopje, Association Prevent, Labyrinth

About: This project aims to improve national policies and practices for preventing gambling among young people under 25 in the Contracting Parties. The main target group is decision-makers and policymakers. Through quantitative and qualitative research, the project seeks to determine the prevalence of gambling among young people, assess the potential addiction developed, and analyze existing legislation and national policies to understand their impact on youth gambling.

Title: SCOUTS UNITED: Learn it, Do it, Scout it

Partners: First Scout Unit of Skopje; Odred izviđača Dr Mladen Stojanović; Odred izviđača Josif Pančić; Izviđački klub EHO

About: This project empowers youth from four Western Balkan countries to create a multicultural network and promote cooperation on peace-building and youth participation.

Through scout exchanges and workshops, participants learn intercultural skills and contribute to social cohesion in their communities, as well to enhanced regional cooperation in the Western Balkans Region.

Title: Balkan Entrepreneur Bridge - Strengthening Western Balkans Young Entrepreneurs Skills for Regional Cooperation

Partners: PHOENIX RISING Skopje, Union of Young Entrepreneurs of Montenegro, Association of Young Entrepreneurs Serbia

About: The project encourages collaboration and good relations among young entrepreneurs from different countries, promoting reconciliation and regional ties. Following the trip, the project facilitates post-trip collaboration to encourage cross-border partnerships and contribute to long-term economic growth and regional stability in the Western Balkans.



Mapping a better future

Diversification, new partnerships, larger grant schemes and rapid growth. Discover what lies ahead in the near future of the Fund

The Western Balkans Fund has made significant progress in the past seven years, focusing on becoming a reliable partner in the region, implementing lessons learned and strengthening its capacities while envisioning sustainable growth.

Looking forward, as we aim to become an even larger organization, we are currently preparing two key documents expected to be adopted in autumn: the Strategic Development Plan 2025-30 and the Fundraising Policies.

The Strategic Development Plan aims to provide a clear roadmap for the future, outlining the organization's priorities and how it intends to achieve them. On the other hand, the Fundraising Policies are designed to enhance the organization's ability to attract and manage funds more effectively, securing its financial health.

These policies will build trust among donors and stakeholders through increased transparency and accountability, and pave the way for forming new partnerships and strengthening existing ones.

Furthermore, in 2024, for the first time since our establishment, we will run four parallel grant schemes: the ERC Grant Scheme, the Annual Grant Scheme, the WBF Move Grants, and the Western Balkans-Visegrad Fellowship.

The diversification process started back in 2020-21 is yielding clear results, and we aim to increase it further.

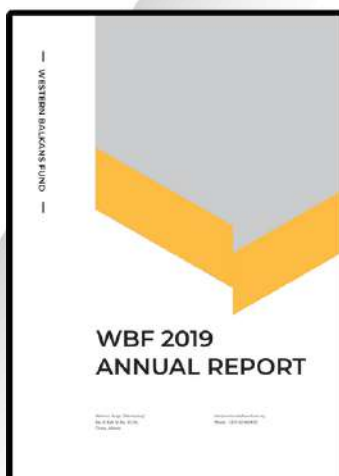
Simultaneously, the Fund will invest in perfecting its Monitoring, Evaluation, and Learning instruments, its regional presence, and our internal capabilities. We will continue to seek to attract the best talent available, convinced of the amazing capabilities of the people of this region.

Finally, our partners remain our biggest asset. The following months will be crucial to further consolidate our growing pool of donors and like-minded partners.

“

*Regional is Good!
Regional is Better! We
believe in cooperation
as the denominator of
a common prosperous
regional future.*

Past Publications



DISCLAIMER

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ANNUAL REPORT

COVERING THE PERIOD
JUNE 2023-JUNE 2024



Visit Our Website

www.westernbalkansfund.org



Contact Us

+355 42 400420